



50 cm
20 in

BORING SPONGE

Cliona celata
F: Clionaidae

Although it appears as yellow lumps, much of this European sponge remains hidden as strands growing through shells and calcareous rocks.



15–30 cm
6–12 in

BORING SPONGE

Cliona delitrix
F: Clionaidae

Water leaves this Caribbean sponge via a number of large oscula (one is shown here). This sponge bores through corals by secreting acid.



30–40 cm
12–16 in

YELLOW FINGER SPONGE

Callyspongia
(*Callyspongia*) *nuda*
F: Callyspongiidae

The bright colour of this tropical Pacific sponge is due to the chemicals it contains. Sponge extracts are used by the pharmaceutical industry.



1 cm/3/8 in

BREADCRUMB SPONGE

Halichondria panicea
F: Halichondriidae

This N.E. Atlantic sponge grows as crusts on rocky shores and in shallow water. Its colour comes from symbiotic algae.



1–2 cm
3/8–3/4 in

SPIRASTRELLA CUNCTATRIX

F: Spirastrellidae

One of many colourful encrusting sponges found in the ocean, this species covers inshore rocks in the Mediterranean and North Atlantic.



2 m/6 1/2 ft

BARREL SPONGE

Xestospongia testudinaria
F: Petrosiidae

Small fish and many invertebrates live on and in this huge Indo-Pacific sponge, which grows big enough to fit a person inside.

APLYSINA ARCHERI

F: Aplysinidae

The graceful long tubes of this sponge sway gently with the current on the Caribbean reefs where it grows.

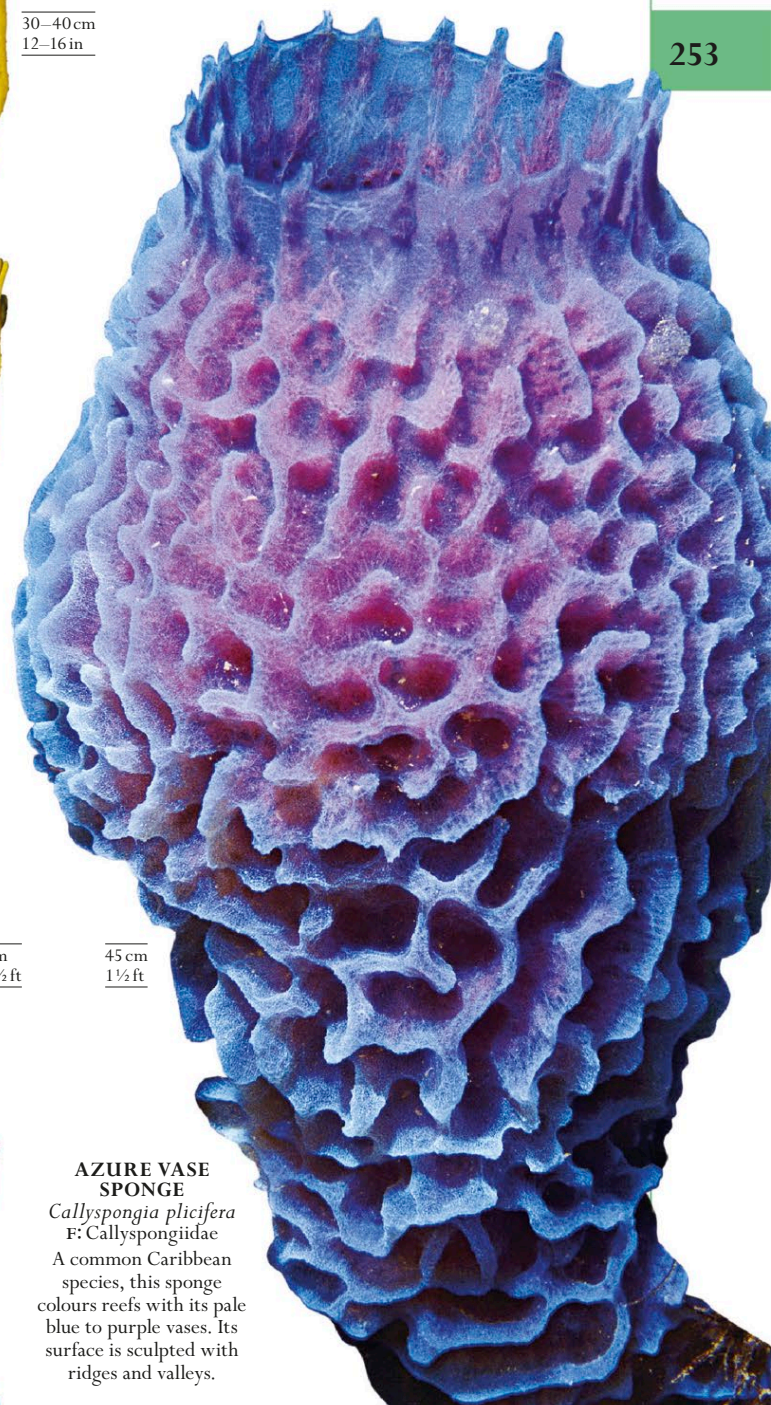


0.8–2 m
2 1/2–6 1/2 ft

AZURE VASE SPONGE

Callyspongia plicifera
F: Callyspongiidae

A common Caribbean species, this sponge colours reefs with its pale blue to purple vases. Its surface is sculpted with ridges and valleys.



45 cm
1 1/2 ft

HOMOSCLEROMORPHA SPONGES

This small class of just under 130 sponges is found in both temperate and tropical waters. They are mostly soft as they have tiny silica spicules or none at all. Their planktonic larvae are unique in form.

CHICKEN LIVER SPONGE

Plakortis lita
F: Plakinidae

The common name of this sponge reflects its look and feel. Dark brown inside and out and smooth to the touch, it is found on coral reefs in the W. Pacific.



10–15 cm
4–6 in

soft coral polyp

GLASS SPONGES

Hexactinellida are a small group of sponges that live mostly in the deep ocean, where some form reef-like mounds up to 20 m (65 ft) high. The six rayed, star-like, silica spicules of the skeleton are usually fused together as a rigid lattice. After death, the skeleton remains as a ghostly outline.



20 cm
8 in

BOLOSOMA GLASS SPONGE

Bolosoma sp.
F: Euplectellidae

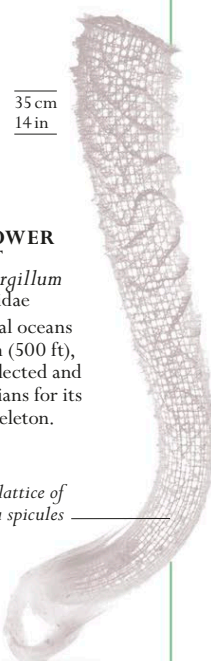
Looking like fat fungi, *Bolosoma* sponges live in the deep sea and are held up into the water currents by a long, thin stalk.

VENUS'S FLOWER BASKET

Euplectella aspergillum
F: Euplectellidae

Growing in tropical oceans below about 150 m (500 ft), this sponge was collected and displayed by Victorians for its delicate silica skeleton.

rigid lattice of
silica spicules



35 cm
14 in